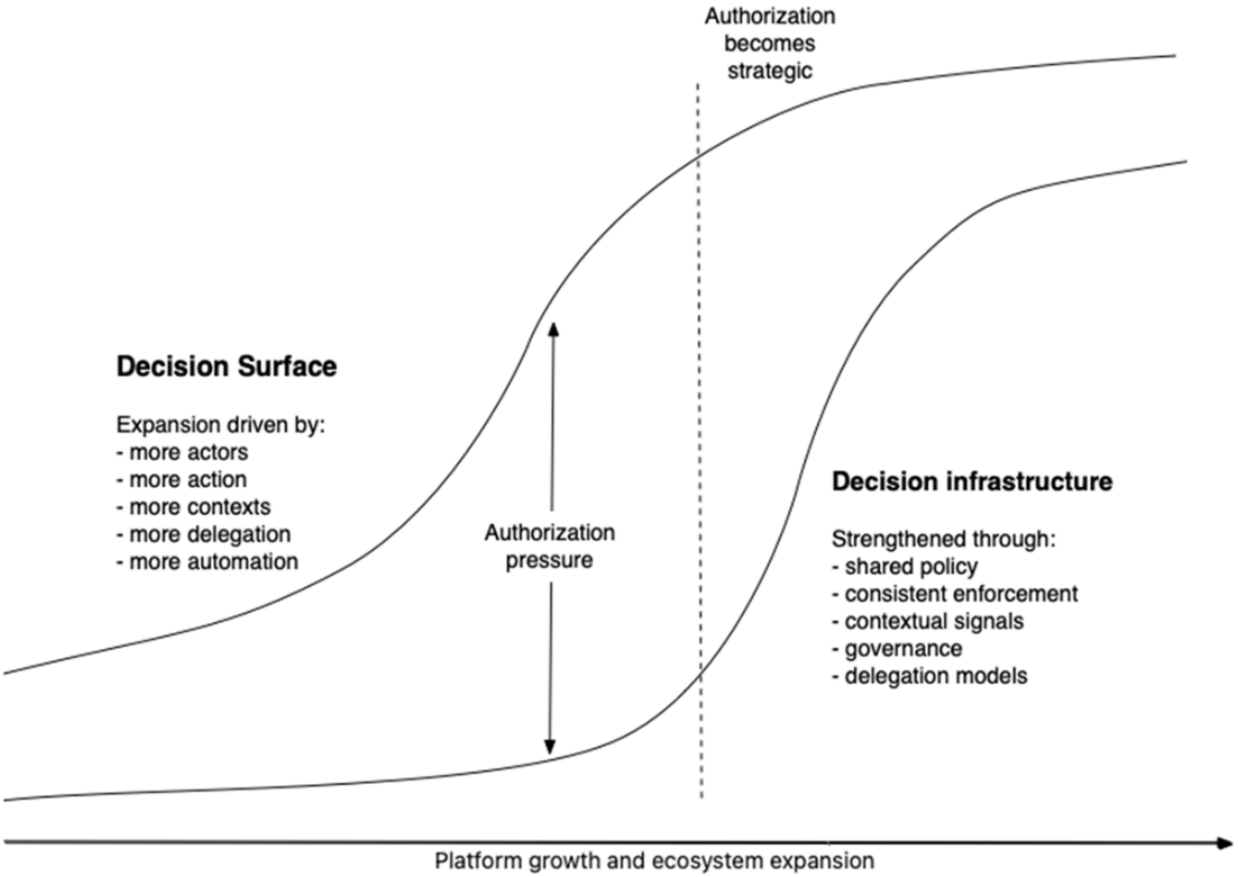


Figure 19.1 Decision surface and decision infrastructure. As systems grow, the decision surface—the set of situations where access must be evaluated—expands faster than the infrastructure that governs those decisions. This gap creates authorization pressure: the growing difficulty of making decisions consistently, explaining outcomes, and maintaining control. Incremental architectural investments can close this gap, enabling organizations to manage trust reliably as complexity grows.

Authorization was no longer just a technical issue. It had become a constraint on ACME's ability to grow quickly. The turning point did not come from a single crisis. Instead, it emerged as leaders across disciplines began describing the same problem in their own words. Engineers talked about duplicated logic and brittle integrations. Security teams focused on limited delegation and decision visibility. Executives worried about stalled partnerships and inconsistent customer experiences. What linked these concerns was that access decisions were being made everywhere but governed nowhere.

When authorization finally became a regular topic in executive reviews, it was not because ACME had failed to act. It was because the organization